ʿIrfan: A Journey into Islamic Mysticism

An Introduction for Seekers

Based on a lecture series by
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Book Two · Expanded edition

DRAFT — not for distribution

An invitation

وَأَنِرْ أَبْصَارَ قُلُوبِنَا بِضِيَاءِ نَظَرِهَا إِلَيْكَ حَتَّىٰ تَخْرِقَ أَبْصَارُ الْقُلُوبِ حُجُبَ النُّورِ فَتَصِلَ إِلَىٰ مَعْدِنِ الْعَظَمَةِ

Enlighten the eyes of our hearts with the light of their looking at You to the extent that they penetrate the veils of light and reach the Source of Grandeur.[1]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

What is 'irfan?

> ***Point:*** *The prayers we already recite ask to see God with the heart and to be near Him, and the Imams wrote them for ordinary believers. We say the words, but seeking to know God does not feature in our daily routine; the obligations do. That less-practised side of the religion is called 'irfan, it is part of the Islam we know, and this book argues it is worth every believer's pursuit.*

These words come from the Munajat Sha'baniyyah, a prayer many of us recite in the month of Sha'ban. The line asks God to light up the eyes of our hearts with the light of looking at Him, until those eyes pass through even the veils of light and reach the source of His grandeur. It is a request to see God with the heart and to be near Him. Requests like this one were written for us, by the Imams (as), as an endeavour for the ordinary believer.

Despite saying these words in our munajats and on auspicious occasions, we find that seeking to know God does not feature in our day-to-day routine. Praying, fasting, and paying what is due, the *wajibat*, are the dominant under-

[1] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165.

taking, and they are what most of us mean by practising the religion. The other side, the one the Munajat describes, in which the believer seeks to know God and to come near Him, is often less practised. That side of the religion is called *ʿirfan*.

ʿIrfan is the Arabic name for what English books call Islamic mysticism, and the two words do not say the same thing. "Mysticism" suggests mystery, something hidden and hard to pin down. The Arabic word names a kind of knowing. It shares its root with *maʿrifah*, knowledge, and an *ʿarif* is, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "someone who knows".

The knowing meant here is not information about God. It is knowing Him from close, with the heart, which is what the Munajat asks for. In Murtada Mutahhari's words, the ʿarif "wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it"[2]. ʿIrfan is that witnessing, and the training of the soul to reach that reality. It is part of the Islam we already know: its sources are the teachings of the Qur'an, the Prophet ﷺ, and the Imams (as) from his Ahl al-Bayt, and the prayer at the head of this page is one of them.

This book is predicated on the belief that every follower of Islam should find ʿirfan a worthwhile pursuit. ʿIrfan travels through the self and never leaves the shariʿa. It is walked by a tested and ordered method. It is rooted in the teachings of the Qur'an, the Prophet ﷺ, and the Imams from his Ahl al-Bayt. And it ends not in withdrawal from the world but in return: to people, with God, and to God Himself.

Who this book is for

> ***Point:*** *Any believer who prays, fasts, and recites duʿas, and has wondered whether the religion has another dimension. No background is needed; the book is a welcoming, brief introduction, with help on terms built in.*

The argument is addressed to anyone who prays, fasts, and recites the duʿas, and who has wondered whether there is more to these acts than getting them right; whether the religion has another dimension. No knowledge of ʿirfan, of philosophy, or of Arabic is assumed. This book strives for brevity and clarity in its role as a welcoming guide to beginning the journey towards ʿirfan. Each

[2] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.

chapter opens with a section that details some of the words you'll meet, along with an explanation, and all terms are gathered in the glossary at the end. Additional call-out sections are spread throughout with helpful context and short side notes.

How the book is built

> ***Point:*** *Five parts, each answering one question in order: why, through what, how, whose, and to what end.*

The book is built in five parts. Each answers one question and depends on the one before.

Part One, *The Call* (Chapters One to Three), asks why a believer should bother. It answers that the Qur'an invites more than the minimum: not only knowing about God, but knowing Him. The goal of ʻirfan is already on our lips in our duʻas.

Part Two, *Getting Ready* (Chapters Four to Seven), describes the landscape a traveller passes through on the journey towards ʻirfan: the self. It also positions the shariʻa as the boundary that keeps the traveller safe, and the guide as the one who walks alongside them.

Part Three, *The Road* (Chapters Eight to Twelve), asks how the path is walked: along the sequence of stages, from repentance through to discipline, love, and finally the loss of the false self.

Part Four, *Fellow Travellers* (Chapters Thirteen to Fifteen), meets those who walked the road before us. It shows the road's roots in the teachings of the Qur'an, the Prophet ﷺ, and the Imams from his Ahl al-Bayt; where its travellers arrived; and how Shia ʻirfan relates to Sufism.

Part Five, *The Destination* (Chapters Sixteen and Seventeen), asks what the voyage is for, with its answer lying in what the traveller brings back: the friends of God return to serve their people, but now with God unveiled in their hearts. Chapter Seventeen then follows every soul on its own return to God.

Where this book comes from

> ***Point:*** *The book is inspired by Sheikh Bahmanpour's lecture series, whose content and structure are its core. It adapts the lectures for print, adds context for a wider readership,*

draws on the Imams' texts and the great Shia scholars, footnotes every source, and presents differing views neutrally.

This book is inspired by a lecture series on Islamic mysticism given by Sheikh M. S. Bahmanpour. The content and structure of those lectures are the core of the book. Wherever the Sheikh is quoted directly, the words are his own and come from his series.

Turning spoken lectures into a book has called for some editorial adaptation. To suit a wider readership, the book also adds context and explanation to support its main arguments. It also draws on the wider literature, from the words of the Imams in Nahj al-Balagha, al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya, and the Mafatih, to the great Shia scholars from across the ages. They range from Sayyid Haydar Amuli in the fourteenth century and Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi at the turn of the twentieth, to modern scholars such as the esteemed 'Allama Tabataba'i, Ayatullah Khomeini, and Ayatullah Mutahhari. Every source is given in a footnote, for readers who want to go further.

The finer questions of 'irfan remain an ongoing conversation among our *'ulama'*: whether a seeker needs a guide from the first step, how much solitude is wise, and how far ordinary believers can travel. Where they differ, this book presents each view with neutrality.

What you can expect

Point: *Three guiding principles frame the book: 'irfan is not sought for powers; it needs no sect or order beside the Imam; and it never steps outside the shari'a. By the end, a reader should be able to say what 'irfan is and begin to practise it alongside the wajibat.*

Three guiding principles frame the discussions in the chapters that follow. The first concerns attempts to gain powers such as mind reading or seeing into the future, which is a folly not associated with a genuine pursuit of 'irfan. As Chapter One shows, Sheikh Bahmanpour and the wider literature both hold to this principle.

The second is that there is no separate sect or order through which 'irfan must be gained. Shia 'irfan has no institution of authority beside the Imam. How this position differs from that of the Sufi orders is explored in Chapter Fifteen.

The third principle is the most important: no part of the journey towards ʻirfan requires stepping outside the shariʻa, and nothing on that journey is gained by doing so. The beginning of ʻirfan, as the Sheikh puts it, is the shariʻa. Far from going around the law or rising above it, the inner path is in fact the law lived from the inside. Nothing in this book asks a reader to set aside the rulings of the jurists or the guidance of their marjaʻ. A fear that mysticism might do exactly that is the primary reason some scholars have been wary of ʻirfan. Chapter Fourteen sets out their wider concerns and the answers given to them.

By the end, a reader should feel able to say what ʻirfan is and is not, why it belongs to us, and what the stages and dangers of the path entail. For those who wish to go further, each chapter and the epilogue offer small, practical steps for bringing this into daily life alongside the wajibat.

PART ONE

The Call

Why travel?

The Qur’an invites more than the minimum: not only knowing about God, but knowing Him. That knowing is reached by purifying the heart, and our own prayers already ask for it.

1 · More than the minimum
2 · Knowing about God is not knowing Him
3 · You already know these words

إِلٰهِي لَمْ يَكُنْ لِي حَوْلٌ فَأَنْتَقِلَ بِهِ عَنْ مَعْصِيَتِكَ إِلاَّ فِي وَقْتٍ أَيْقَظْتَنِي لِمَحَبَّتِكَ

My Lord, I was not strong enough to move away from Your disobedience, except when You awakened me to Your love.

Munajat Sha‘baniyyah

1

More than the minimum

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ ﴿٢١﴾

There are indeed signs in that for a people who reflect.

Qur'an 30:21

At many weddings, someone recites a verse most of us know. In Surah al-Rum, God says that He created spouses for us from among ourselves "that you may take comfort in them", and that He ordained "affection and mercy" between husband and wife (Q 30:21). The verse ends with the words above: this is a sign for a people who reflect. The sign is there for everyone, yet, as with beauty, seeing it lies in the eye of the beholder. It depends on something inside the person doing the looking. That something, and why it is worth seeking above and beyond the minimum, is what this chapter sets out to explore.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *'Irfan*: knowing God from close · *ma'rifah*: knowledge of God · *'arif* (plural *'urafa'*): one who knows God · *muqarrabun*: those brought near to God · *awliya' Allah*: the friends of God · *shirk*: setting up a partner beside God

What the minimum leaves out

Point: *The obligations save, but the Qur’an asks for more: to reflect on, know, listen to and reason about its signs.*

1. *A believer who keeps the obligations can hope for jannah; that is not contested.* (Story box: what was enough for jannah, and the Sheikh’s question: then why do more?)
2. *This book disputes a second claim: that the obligations are the whole of the religion.*
3. *The Qur’an answers it: Surah al-Rum names three more sets of signs, and each ends by saying whom the sign is for.*
4. *Four times running, the signs are “for” those who reflect, know, listen and reason; that is what the Qur’an asks beyond the minimum.*
5. *This “more” never bypasses the law.*
6. *Therefore: the obligations save, but the Qur’an asks for more.*

Let’s start with what nobody disputes. A believer who prays, fasts, pays what is due, and goes on hajj can hope for *jannah*, provided they do what is *wajib* and avoid what is forbidden. Sheikh Bahmanpour accepts this as fair for ordinary believers, and Mohammad Ali Shomali adds that the obligatory rules of fiqh are “the minimally necessary conditions of human perfection”[3].

STORY: WHAT WAS ENOUGH FOR JANNAH

Someone once came to the Prophet ﷺ and said that they had no eagerness for the night prayer (*salat al-layl*), the recommended fasts, and the like. They asked whether they would go to jannah if they prayed the five daily prayers, fasted in Ramadan, paid their zakat, and went on hajj once. The Prophet said yes. Sheikh Bahmanpour opens his first lecture with this story and draws his question from the Prophet’s answer: if the obligatory acts are enough for jannah, why take on the hard work of ‘irfan?

Some jurists and activists go further, and this point of contention delineates those who reject ‘irfan from those who seek it, with this book being a guide for the latter. Those jurists’ claim is that the obligatory acts make up the whole of the religion, and that anything beyond them is not grounded in evidence but in mystical fancies.

The Qur’an answers this narrow view a few lines after the wedding verse, pointing in Surah al-Rum to three further sets of signs: the creation of the heavens and the earth, with the variety of our languages and colours; our sleep and our work; and the lightning and the rain that revives the dead earth (Q

[3]Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 17.

30:22–24). Like the wedding verse, each of them ends by naming the people the sign is for.

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّلْعَالِمِينَ ﴿٢٢﴾

There are indeed signs in that for those who know.

Qur'an 30:22

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَسْمَعُونَ ﴿٢٣﴾

There are indeed signs in that for a people who listen.

Qur'an 30:23

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ ﴿٢٤﴾

There are indeed signs in that for people who exercise their reason.

Qur'an 30:24

Four times in a row, the Qur'an makes the same point. The signs are all around us: in marriage, in the people we meet, in sleep, in work, and in the weather. Yet they are for those who reflect, know, listen, and reason. This reflecting, knowing, listening, and reasoning is what the Qur'an asks of us beyond the minimum.

For the avoidance of doubt, this invitation from the Qur'an is not an invitation to circumvent the law or to abandon the prescribed wajibat. Ayatullah Khomeini insists that a genuine seeker's devotion "is within the bounds of the Shari'ah"[4]. Within those bounds, the Qur'an is just as insistent: it invites us to more than the obligatory acts.

Signs most people miss

> ***Point:*** *Most of us, the devout included, do not perceive those signs.*
>
> *1. An invitation to those who reflect implies that many do not, the devout included.*

[4]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

2. *Accepting that a sign exists because the Qur'an says so is not perceiving it, and the Qur'an names that gap (Q 12:105).*
3. *A sign points beyond itself, like a red light; most of us see only the lamp (Tabataba'i).*
4. *Therefore: most of us do not perceive the signs.*

An invitation addressed to those who reflect, know, listen, and reason implies that many people do none of these things. This is not limited to the careless. Most pious people, even those careful about the shariʿa, do not find a sign in these verses. Looking at the variety of languages and colours, we are more likely to see a reason for division than a sign of God.

We have heard these verses many times and, as the Sheikh puts it, accept them out of obedience: "you say there are signs, so there are signs." Accepting that a sign exists is still not the same as perceiving it, and the Qur'an describes that gap in a single verse.

وَكَأَيِّن مِّنْ ءَايَةٍ فِي ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ يَمُرُّونَ عَلَيْهَا وَهُمْ عَنْهَا مُعْرِضُونَ ﴿١٠٥﴾

How many a sign there is in the heavens and the earth that they pass by while they are disregardful of it!

Qur'an 12:105

ʿAllama Tabataba'i explains what passing by a sign means; a person who sees a red light thinks of the danger it warns of, not of the colour and shape of the lamp. In the same way, the things of the world are signs, and "what the signs indicate is not this world, but the person of its Creator"[5]. Most of us see only the lamp. We witness the rain as rain and the marriage as a marriage, and we pass them by without perceiving what they say about their Creator.

The fault is in the receiver

Point: *Since the signs are plain and we miss them, the fault is a faculty in us; it has rusted, so it can be repaired.*

1. *If the signs are plain and we still miss them, the fault is ours; the Qur'an names it: hearts, eyes and ears unused (Q 7:179).*
2. *Cattle see and hear, so the fault is not in the senses but in the faculty behind them that turns sight into understanding.*

[5]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 6–7.

3. *That faculty is the soul, a machine that has rusted; ʿirfan is its repair (the Sheikh).*
4. *This has two consequences.* (Reader told: "two consequences".)
   a. *The problem is not a lack of evidence: God is not withholding signs.*
   b. *The problem can be solved: a rusted faculty can be repaired, and the pull towards God is part of how we are made (Kernel). So the fault is in us, and it can be repaired.*
5. *Repair only starts a journey with "a beginning and no end".* (Breather, kept by the user.)

If the signs are present and plain, and yet we still pass them by, the fault is on our side. Of those who possess every faculty and yet use none of them, the Qur'an makes clear their fault.

لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ لَّا يَفْقَهُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَّا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ ءَاذَانٌ لَّا يَسْمَعُونَ بِهَآ
أُوْلَٰٓئِكَ كَٱلْأَنْعَٰمِ بَلْ هُمْ أَضَلُّ

they have hearts with which they do not understand, they have eyes with which they do not see, they have ears with which they do not hear. They are like cattle; indeed, they are more astray.

Qur'an 7:179

Cattle see and hear perfectly well, so the comparison cannot be about the senses. It is about what lies behind the senses. Eyes and ears take in the surface of things, whereas inside a human being there should be something more: a faculty, which animals lack, that turns what the senses take in into understanding. In most of us, it is not working.

Sheikh Bahmanpour compares this faculty to a machine. The ear catches the sound, but "there is something inside which doesn't catch it. There is a machine inside which is [rusted]." That machine is the soul. It has to be repaired before it can catch the signals of God. This is the whole subject in one sentence: mysticism is about making the soul hear, see, and reflect. It is not easy, and it requires a great deal of training.

If the fault lies in the receiver, two things follow. One is that we have never lacked evidence; the signs are there, and we have failed to receive them.

The other, more hopeful, is that the problem can be solved. A faculty that exists but has rusted gives us the solace of knowing that rust can be abrased, whereas a faculty that is absent can never be made present. The *Kernel of the*

Kernels, a record of ‘Allama Tabataba’i’s early lectures on the path, opens by saying that the pull towards the unseen is “part of the innate instincts of the human being”[6]. The longing for God, and the faculty that perceives Him, are part of how we are made.

Repair is only the start. Once the inner faculty begins to work, a journey begins that, in the Sheikh’s words, “has a beginning and no end”.

Some do see

> ***Point:*** *If the faculty can be repaired, some have repaired it: the Qur’an describes believers in whom it works, the ‘urafa’.*
>
> 1. *If it can be repaired, there should be people in whom it works; the tradition calls them the ‘urafa’, ordinary believers, not prophets. The Qur’an describes them in four ways.* (Reader told: “four ways”.)
>   a. *Their hearts tremble at God’s mention (Q 8:2), so they know Him.*
>   b. *They “possess knowledge” and bear witness to His oneness (Q 3:18): they witness what others only say.*
>   c. *They fear Him (Q 35:28), and not only His punishment.*
>   d. *They are the friends of God (Q 10:62), who in Imam ‘Ali’s words see the world’s reality when others see its surface.*
> 2. *Seeing inside the world does not mean leaving it: they live among people, with their hearts on God.*
> 3. *Therefore: in some believers the faculty works.*

If the faculty can be repaired, there should be people in whom it already works. The Qur’an describes them in four verses. Perhaps the simplest way humans can divide themselves is also the most revealing, separating those with a working soul and those with a broken one. The first are the *‘urafa’* (the plural of *‘arif*). While the prophets and the Imams (as) are a class of their own, the ‘urafa’ are ordinary believers who see more than the rest. Surah al-Anfal gives the first of these descriptions.

إِنَّمَا ٱلْمُؤْمِنُونَ ٱلَّذِينَ إِذَا ذُكِرَ ٱللَّهُ وَجِلَتْ قُلُوبُهُمْ

The faithful are only those whose hearts tremble [with awe] when Allah is mentioned,

Qur’an 8:2

[6] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 4.

A heart does not dwell on what it does not know, and much less can it feel what it has not felt; only from intimate experience can a heart tremble with true knowledge. The believers of this verse are thus the believers who know Allah. A verse in Surah Al 'Imran goes further and gives them another name.

شَهِدَ ٱللَّهُ أَنَّهُۥ لَآ إِلَٰهَ إِلَّا هُوَ وَٱلْمَلَٰٓئِكَةُ وَأُو۟لُوا۟ ٱلْعِلْمِ

Allah ... bears witness that there is no god except Him, and [so do] the angels and those who possess knowledge.

Qur'an 3:18

For Sheikh Bahmanpour, "those who possess knowledge" is another name for the 'urafa'. Every Muslim knows that there is no god but Allah and says so in every prayer, yet our knowledge of *tawhid*, God's oneness, is not the knowledge of those who witness it. Tawhid is simple to say and hard to grasp, and its depths are reached by the awakened soul rather than by the intellect alone. Surah Fatir describes the same people by what they feel.

إِنَّمَا يَخْشَى ٱللَّهَ مِنْ عِبَادِهِ ٱلْعُلَمَٰٓؤُا۟

Only those of Allah's servants having knowledge fear Him.

Qur'an 35:28

Most of us fear Allah's punishment. The people of this verse fear Him with a fear that is not about punishment at all.

In Surah Yunus they are the *awliya' Allah*, the friends of God (Q 10:62). Imam 'Ali (as) describes what these friends see that others miss.

[VERIFY: Arabic of Nahj 3.403 from Qutbuddin p. 810]

God's special devotees are those who perceive the world's reality when others are deceived by her appearance. They occupy themselves with what is coming when others occupy themselves with the present.[7]

Nahj al-Balagha

[7] Imam 'Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 3.403.

Where other people look at the surface of the world, the friends of God look at what lies inside it. None of this means turning away from the world. There is nothing wrong with being rich, so long as the wealth does not take up the heart, and the friends of God have families, friends, and a place in society, as we do. Their thoughts are on God rather than on themselves, and in their hearts they are cut off from everything else.

What they are given, and why it is open to all

> ***Point:*** *What they are given is worth having, and their rank is open to every believer.*
>
> 1. *The Qur'an names three things they are given.* (Reader told: "three".)
>   a. *Nearness: they are "brought near" (Q 56:10–11), a veil removed.*
>   b. *A good life (Q 16:97): clean, above the worries that occupy everyone else.*
>   c. *Freedom from fear and grief (Q 10:62).*
> 2. *This is not only for prophets: Q 4:69 names four ranks, and the fourth, the righteous, is a doorway open to us.*
> 3. *We are made for it: "we are not yet human beings", but God created us able to become His friends.*
> 4. *So far: the Qur'an invites more, what stops us can be repaired, and beyond the repair lie nearness, a good life and peace, open to any believer.*
> 5. *Therefore: what they have is worth having, and within our reach.*

Of the three gifts the Qur'an names for these people, nearness comes first. Surah al-Waqiʿa sorts people on the Last Day, and at the top it places the Foremost Ones.

وَٱلسَّـٰبِقُونَ ٱلسَّـٰبِقُونَ ﴿١٠﴾ أُو۟لَـٰٓئِكَ ٱلْمُقَرَّبُونَ ﴿١١﴾

And the Foremost Ones are the foremost ones: they are the ones brought near [to Allah],

Qur'an 56:10-11

The Arabic for "brought near" is *muqarrabun*. God is not far from anyone. Being brought near means that a veil between the person and God has been removed, so that they understand far more.

Surah al-Nahl promises the second, a different kind of life, to whoever acts righteously, man or woman, while having faith.

مَنْ عَمِلَ صَٰلِحًا مِّن ذَكَرٍ أَوْ أُنثَىٰ وَهُوَ مُؤْمِنٌ فَلَنُحْيِيَنَّهُۥ حَيَوٰةً طَيِّبَةً

Whoever acts righteously, [whether] male or female, should he be faithful, We shall revive him with a good life

Qur'an 16:97

This good and clean life (*hayat tayyiba*) is the life that mystics seek. Its people live in the world without being soiled by it, rising above the worries that occupy everyone else.

The third, peace, is promised in the verse of Surah Yunus that names the friends of God.

أَلَآ إِنَّ أَوْلِيَآءَ ٱللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ ﴿٦٢﴾

Look! The friends of Allah will indeed have no fear nor will they grieve

Qur'an 10:62

For the muqarrabun, who have no fear and do not grieve, the terms are entirely different from those of ordinary believers.

None of this would matter to an ordinary reader if it were reserved for prophets. Surah al-Nisa' answers that concern.

وَمَن يُطِعِ ٱللَّهَ وَٱلرَّسُولَ فَأُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ مَعَ ٱلَّذِينَ أَنْعَمَ ٱللَّهُ عَلَيْهِم مِّنَ ٱلنَّبِيِّـۧنَ وَٱلصِّدِّيقِينَ وَٱلشُّهَدَآءِ وَٱلصَّٰلِحِينَ وَحَسُنَ أُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ رَفِيقًا ﴿٦٩﴾

Whoever obeys Allah and the Apostle—they are with those whom Allah has blessed, including the prophets and the truthful, the martyrs and the righteous, and excellent companions are they!

Qur'an 4:69

In this verse the Sheikh finds four ranks of those God has blessed: the prophets; the truthful (*siddiqin*); the *shuhada'*, which the translation used here renders "martyrs" and which he takes as "the witnesses"; and the righteous (*salihin*). The first three ranks are beyond us, but the fourth is a doorway. The salihin are those able to receive this favour, and from among them God chooses the

truthful and the prophets. The way in is righteous action, as the verse on the good life also says.

That doorway is open to people like us. It is difficult, but we are made for it. We call ourselves human beings, yet, in the Sheikh’s words, “we are not yet human beings”: we begin with the capacity to become human in the full sense that the prophets are, and God wants us to reach it.

This is the case for pursuing ‘irfan. The Qur’an invites more than the minimum, and what stands in the way is a faculty in us that can be repaired. On the other side of that repair lie nearness to God, a good life, and freedom from fear and grief. Surah al-Nisa’ opens that rank to any believer who obeys God and the Prophet and acts righteously.

The aim is God, not powers

> ***Point:*** *The repair is training the soul, and that training must aim at God alone, never at powers.*
>
> 1. *Repair means training the soul, and soul-training can aim at powers: being in two places at once, seeing the future.*
> 2. *The Sheikh: ‘irfan is not about powers; seeking them is shirk.*
> 3. *The great Shia teachers agree, each in his own words.* (Reader told: “each in his own words”; a nuanced point, so three scholars, TONE 43.)
>   a. *Tabataba’i: the traveller has no right to seek powers; whoever does worships his own self.* (Who’s Who box.)
>   b. *Khomeini, from his teacher Shahabadi: exercises meant for powers are invalid.*
>   c. *Mutahhari: any goal but God is a kind of shirk, because the goal has become something other than God.*
> 4. *Therefore: the scholars differ in emphasis but agree that the aim is God alone, not powers.* (Short closing paragraph, kept by the user.)

Pursuing ‘irfan means training the soul, and soul-training is not unique to Islam. People take up the inner life for different reasons. Some train the soul in an attempt to gain power: to be in two places at once, to see the future or the past, or to master the hidden world of the soul. Such attempts are folly and not in the spirit of a genuine pursuit of ‘irfan. Islamic mysticism is about catching the signs of Allah: becoming sensitive to them, and learning to hear and see.

Sheikh Bahmanpour ends his first lecture more strongly. ‘Irfan, he says, is not about gaining power over the soul to work the wonders of the saints

(*karamat*) or the miracles of the prophets (*mu'jizat*). Such powers are *shirk*: the sin of setting up a partner beside God.

Each in their own words, the great teachers of the Shia tradition make closely related points. 'Allama Tabataba'i tells the traveller that he "has no right to seek occult experiences and miraculous qualities", nor to perform austerities or recite invocations to gain powers such as crossing great distances in a moment or reading the thoughts of others. Whoever does so "does not move on the path of the Beloved's pleasure and his worship is not for the sake of God". It is his own self that he worships, "though he may not admit it by word of mouth"[8].

> ◈ **WHO'S WHO: 'ALLAMA TABATABA'I**
>
> Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Tabataba'i is best known as the author of *al-Mizan*, a commentary on the Qur'an in twenty volumes[9]. His student Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Husayni Tihrani describes him as having flown "with the two wings of knowledge and action". He travelled the path in both philosophy and gnosis under the guidance of the gnostic Mirza 'Ali Aqa Qadi, and after years of philosophical argument he "came to settle down at the sacred threshold of the Qur'an"[10]. *Kernel of the Kernels* (*Lubb al-Lubab*) is Tihrani's record of the lectures on ethics and gnosis that Tabataba'i gave to students in Qum in 1949–50[11]. He also wrote the preface to *Light Within Me*[12], from which several quotations in this chapter come.

Ayatullah Khomeini reports the test his teacher Ayatullah Shahabadi used: the measure of true spiritual effort is how much selfishness is in it. If a traveller's "spiritual exercises are meant for acquiring powers for worldly ends, his efforts are rendered invalid"[13].

Murtada Mutahhari echoes the Sheikh's words, again using the word *shirk*. The 'urafa', he writes, consider it "a kind of shirk (polytheism) for one's goal in life and particularly in worship to be something other than God Himself", and

[8] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), pp. 28–29.
[9] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 30.
[10] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 8.
[11] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 9.
[12] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.
[13] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

he recalls Imam ʿAli (as) saying that he worshipped God not from fear of His Fire or desire for His Paradise but because he found Him worthy of worship[14].

The scholars differ in emphasis but agree that powers are not the aim. Mutahhari also explains why seeking them would be shirk: the goal has become something other than God.

Seeking, and nothing else

> ***Point:*** *ʿIrfan is seeking the knowledge and love of God and nothing else, and it is worth pursuing.*
>
> 1. *With powers set aside, the Sheikh's definition remains: ʿirfan "is actually seeking and nothing else": the knowledge of God and the love of God.* (Word Study box.)
> 2. *Therefore ʿirfan is worth pursuing: the training of the soul to perceive and love God, open to every believer, and sought for God alone.*
>
> *Close: "If the aim is to know and love God, what kind of knowing is that?"*

With powers set aside, what remains is the definition Sheikh Bahmanpour gives at the end of his first lecture: ʿirfan "is actually seeking and nothing else". It seeks the knowledge of God (*maʿrifah*) and the love of God (*mahabba*).

> ع **WORD STUDY: ʿIRFAN AND MAʿRIFAH**
>
> *ʿIrfan*, *maʿrifah*, *ʿarif* and its plural *ʿurafa'* belong to one family of words about knowing. An ʿarif, as Sheikh Bahmanpour puts it, is "someone who knows". "Mystic" is used of Christians, Hindus, and Buddhists alike; ʿarif is the Islamic word, and it means something more distinct. Murtada Mutahhari draws the line. The philosopher wants a correct picture of the world in his mind. The ʿarif "wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it"[15]. *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (as), says that there is no way to God except through knowledge[16]. What kind of knowledge that is, and how it differs from what we learn from books, is the subject of Chapter Two.

ʿIrfan is therefore worth pursuing: it is the training of the soul to perceive and love God, open to every believer, and sought for God alone.

If the aim is to know and love God, what kind of knowing is that?

[14] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 44.
[15] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.
[16] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 9.

➤ TRY THIS

Sheikh Bahmanpour builds his first lesson on the four signs of Surah al-Rum. For one week, read Q 30:21–24 slowly once a day. After each verse, ask yourself what he found in its ending: whether you reflect, whether you know, whether you listen, and whether you use your reason. Then, at some point in the day, notice one of the four signs where it occurs in your life: the affection in your home, the languages and colours of the people you meet, your own sleep and the work that earns your living, or the rain.

2

Knowing about God is not knowing Him

On a day of fasting in Ramadan, by late afternoon, no one has to be told that they are hungry. They do not read it in a book or work it out from the clock. The hunger is known from the inside. Sheikh Bahmanpour uses hunger to describe a kind of knowing that study cannot give.

Most of what we know of God is of the kind gained by study. We learn the rulings of fiqh, the beliefs the scholars set out, and the history of the Prophet ﷺ and the Imams (as). All of it is knowledge about God. The Qur'an's invitation to more than the minimum is an invitation to knowing God like a fasting person knows hunger: intimately and undoubtedly. This chapter defines the difference between knowing God and knowing about God, and then explores how He comes to be known.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *ʿIlm*: knowledge, especially knowledge gained by study · *ʿilm al-husuli*: acquired knowledge · *ʿilm al-huduri*: knowledge by presence · *ʿaql*: the reasoning intellect · *suluk*: wayfaring; the path of purification

Knowing about, and knowing

Point: *The ʿarif knows God by presence, not by definition.*

1. *There are two kinds of knowing.* (Reader told: "Let's start with the two kinds of knowing.")
    a. *Acquired knowledge reaches us from outside, through the senses or by reasoning; what we know about God is of this kind.*
    b. *It works by defining, and to define a thing is to limit it.*
    c. *Knowledge by presence is already with the soul, as our self and our hunger are.*
    d. *It is complete: nothing of the hunger is missed, and even a false hunger is felt as real.*
2. *The mystics seek knowledge by presence: to arrive at God, as a fasting person arrives at hunger. (That a definition limits God is shown in §1 step 1b and in "Where reason stops".)*
3. *Ayatullah Khomeini records the same line between two kinds of people: the ʿarif knows God by witnessing, which is knowledge by presence; the scholar by proofs, which is acquired knowledge.*
4. *Therefore: the ʿarif knows God by presence, not by definition.* (Word Study box.)

Let's start with the two kinds of knowing. The first is acquired knowledge (*ʿilm al-husuli*). It reaches us from outside, through the senses or by reasoning. We form concepts of the things around us and then analyse those concepts. Almost everything we learn from teachers and books is of this kind, including what we know about God.

Acquired knowledge works by defining its object. To understand a thing, we sort it into a category and mark where it ends and something else begins. The Arabic word for a definition (*hadd*) also means a limit: to define a thing is to limit it. The old definition of a human being as "the rational animal" works by drawing a line around us.

The second kind is knowledge by presence (*ʿilm al-huduri*). It does not come from outside and needs no concept to be understood; it is already with the soul. The clearest case of knowledge by presence is knowing that we exist. Nobody teaches us that, we don't reason our way to it, and we can't be wrong about it. We simply know it from the inside. Hunger, pain, and anxiety are further examples known in the same way. Each may have an external cause, but the feeling itself arises inside us.

Knowledge by presence is complete. When the body is hungry, the soul knows it at once and without effort, and nothing of the hunger is missed. The hunger may even be false, and yet what is felt is real. A person may be wrong to think that their body needs food. They cannot be wrong that they feel hungry.

Knowledge by presence is what the mystics are after. Sheikh Bahmanpour defines mysticism as the urge to reach out to the infinite through knowledge by presence. Acquired knowledge (*ʿilm*) aims at understanding, whereas knowledge by presence (*maʿrifah*) aims at arriving. A person during the meal of iftar cannot understand hunger as sharply as they will understand it during the next day's fast, despite having spent most of their day hungry. There is no substitute for arriving in that moment. In this way, mystics seek to arrive at God.

Ayatullah Khomeini describes the scholar and the ʿarif in distinct terms, with each earning their own label; the scholar is the one who acquires knowledge and thereby "attains the knowledge of God through philosophical proofs", whereas the ʿarif is the one who gains knowledge through presence and so "knows God through direct witnessing"[17].

> ع **WORD STUDY: ʿILM AL-HUSULI AND ʿILM AL-HUDURI**
>
> *Husul* means acquiring or obtaining, whereas *hudur* means presence. In acquired knowledge (*ʿilm al-husuli*), what reaches the mind is a concept or an image of the thing, while the thing itself stays outside. In knowledge by presence (*ʿilm al-huduri*), the thing known is itself present to the soul, as our own self, our hunger, and our pain are present. The phrase Ayatullah Khomeini uses for the gnostic's witnessing, *mushahada huduriyya* (witnessing by presence), comes from the same root. Sheikh Bahmanpour notes that the religious texts use *ʿilm* and *maʿrifah* for the same thing, whereas Ayatullah Khomeini writes of "an evident difference" between *ʿirfan* and *ʿilm*[18]. This book keeps the two apart to make the two kinds of knowing easier to see. Chapter One's Word Study noted that there is no way to God except through knowledge, and left open what type of knowledge it refers to. If *maʿrifah* is arriving, as this chapter describes it, that knowledge is knowledge by presence.

Where reason stops

> ***Point:*** *Reason cannot reach God Himself, so He must be known by presence, within the soul.*
>
> 1. *Acquired knowledge is the work of reason, and reason knows a thing's attributes, never the thing itself (Ibn Sina).*

[17] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 542.
[18] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 542.

2. *If reason stops short of ordinary things, it stops further short of God, who has no colour or size for the mind to hold.*
3. *Imam ʿAli: neither the widest nor the deepest reason reaches God, who has no boundaries; there is no line to draw round Him.*
4. *Reason can still argue that God exists and say what He is not; this is knowledge about God, and apart from the proof, it is negative.*
5. *ʿIrfan seeks the positive side, His attributes known from within; only knowledge by presence can know God (Mulla Sadra).*
6. *Therefore: we know by presence only what is within us, where a faint sense of God already lives, so God must be known within the soul.* (Who's Who box.)

Acquired knowledge is the work of reason (*ʿaql*), the faculty by which we understand and argue. Reason has a limit. When we know a thing, we know its attributes: its colour, its size, and what it does. Every description says that it is brown, square, or useful, and none says what the "it" is. Ibn Sina, the master of philosophy, granted this. The reality of things, he held, is beyond the reach of human reason.

If reason cannot reach what the things around us are, it falls still further short of God, who has no colour or size for the mind to take hold of. Imam ʿAli (as) speaks of reason's limit at the opening of the first oration in *Nahj al-Balagha*, where he praises God.

لا يدركه بعد الهمم ولا يناله غوص الفطن

Soaring thoughts cannot reach him and deep minds cannot fathom him.[19]

Nahj al-Balagha

The two images can be read as reason at its widest range and reason at its deepest, and Imam ʿAli says that neither reaches God. The next sentence of the oration continues: God "cannot be described, for he is beyond the limits of demarcated boundaries"[20]. A definition draws a line round its object, and there is no line to draw round God.

Reason can still argue that God exists, and it can say what He is not: God cannot be an object, and He is not in one place and absent from another. All

[19]Imam ʿAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.1.1.
[20]Imam ʿAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.1.1.

of this is knowledge about God. Apart from the proof that He exists, the rest is negative knowledge, in which each statement says what God is not, rather than saying what He is.

ʿIrfan asks for the positive side. We cannot know God's essence. What ʿirfan seeks is His attributes, known positively: God as the Merciful, the Compassionate, and the Forgiving. The names can be learned from a book. To know God as Merciful from within, as a hungry person knows their hunger, is knowledge by presence. Mulla Sadra held that knowledge by presence is the only way to know the reality of anything, and the only way to know God. The comparison with hunger is an example of this knowledge's attainment and not its extent. As the Sheikh puts it frankly, "the more you know, the more bewildered you will become".

We have knowledge by presence only of what is within us: our own self and some of its states. A sense of God already lives there, however faint: a vague idea of God that we carry inside us. If God is to be known, and not only known about, the knowing must happen within the soul.

◈ WHO'S WHO: MULLA SADRA AND THE SCHOOLS OF PHILOSOPHY

Mulla Sadra died in 1050/1640[21]. In Sheikh Bahmanpour's account, Islamic philosophy before him had two branches: the Peripatetic (*al-hikma al-mashsha'iyya*) and the Illuminationist. Mulla Sadra changed its course. He called his own philosophy neither of these but the transcendent philosophy (*al-hikma al-muta'aliya*). He claimed for it a rationalised mysticism, giving rational argument to what the mystics know only by experience. For Murtada Mutahhari, the philosopher works with "reason, deductions and proofs", whereas the ʿarif works with "the heart and the purification, disciplining and perfecting of the self"[22]. Mulla Sadra studied the ʿirfan of Ibn ʿArabi deeply without belonging to any Sufi order, and rated Ibn ʿArabi above Ibn Sina[23]. *Kernel of the Kernels* records that after a lifetime in philosophy he became absorbed in worship and the purification of his inner being. He asked God's pardon for the part of his life spent studying "the opinions of the pseudo-philosophers and polemicists from among the theologians", until "it became clear to me that their syllogisms were barren and their path devoid of straightness"[24].

[21] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 40.
[22] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 42.
[23] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 35, 40.
[24] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 7.

Light in the heart

Point: *Knowledge of God is a light God gives to a purified heart, and study cannot gather it.*

1. *Study alone cannot give this knowledge; a hadith says it is a light God casts into the heart of whomever He wills (Forty Hadith p. 331).*
2. *"Whomever He wills" means receiving the light is not a foregone conclusion; the Verse of Light says the same: God is the light of the heavens and the earth, and He guides to His light whom He wishes (Q 24:35).*
3. *God chooses those He loves, so the traveller purifies the heart first, in hope (L03 ¶47); Q 2:282 names where purity begins: be wary of Allah and He will teach you.*
4. *Wariness (*taqwa*) is a shield guarding the soul, grown from fear and awe of God; it purifies the soul, and divine teaching follows, since God withholds nothing (Forty Hadith pp. 198, 291, 331).*
5. *As with the signs in Chapter One, the light is everywhere and a dark heart shuts it out (L03 ¶20); receiving it asks for the purity wariness brings.*
6. *Therefore: knowledge of God is a light given to a purified heart, and study cannot gather it.* (Story box: A thousand doors of knowledge, D47, shows such knowledge passing heart to heart.)

The limits of study alone are described in a hadith that Ayatullah Khomeini quotes in his *Forty Hadith*:

[VERIFY: Arabic of the hadith from Forty Hadith p. 331]

Knowledge is not extensive learning. Rather, it is a light that God casts in the heart of whomever He wills.[25]

Hadith

It is clear that God's light is needed to succeed in the pursuit of this kind of knowledge. However, the phrase "whomever He wills" highlights that the receiving of this light is not a foregone conclusion. The Verse of Light in Surah al-Nur adds Qur'anic weight to this sentiment:

ٱللَّهُ نُورُ ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ ۚ

Allah is the Light of the heavens and the earth.

Qur'an 24:35

[25] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 331.

يَهۡدِي ٱللَّهُ لِنُورِهِۦ مَن يَشَآءُۚ

Allah guides to His Light whomever He wishes.

Qur’an 24:35

In a desire to obtain this light that is knowledge, we ask ourselves how God chooses whom He guides. The Sheikh’s answer is that He chooses those He loves. Therefore, the traveller purifies the heart, “in the hope that Allah will choose you”. Surah al-Baqarah explains the form of this purification:

وَٱتَّقُواْ ٱللَّهَۖ وَيُعَلِّمُكُمُ ٱللَّهُۗ

Be wary of Allah and Allah will teach you.

Qur’an 2:282

“Be wary” is the verb form of *taqwa*, with *taqwa* itself tracing back to a root meaning shield, so that being wary is “a kind of defense and shielding”[26]. Wariness guards the soul against whatever goes against what pleases God, and it grows from “the fear and awe of God Almighty”[27].

Ayatullah Khomeini continues to say that guarding is why wariness comes first and God’s teaching follows. Wariness, he writes, “purifies the soul and connects it to the invisible sacred realm”, and divine teaching follows, “for there is no niggardliness in the higher realms, which are bounteous by necessity”[28].

Chapter One found the signs are everywhere but not picked up by our faulty receivers. Similarly, the light that brings knowledge surrounds us, though the guiding of this light, as with all things, is God’s alone to give. “The light is everywhere,” the Sheikh says, and if a heart stays dark, it is because the heart shuts out the light. To open the heart’s shutters, we must purify the heart with the wariness of God.

Knowledge of God is therefore a light given to a purified heart, and study cannot gather it. A knowledge given to the heart also travels differently. The knowledge of books passes from mind to mouth, through language, whereas

[26]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 198.
[27]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 291.
[28]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 331.

the knowledge of the ʿurafa' passes "from heart to heart", in the Sheikh's words. Receiving it directly from God is possible but difficult, so one usually has to start through someone else, and Chapter Seven describes that guide.

> **STORY: A THOUSAND DOORS OF KNOWLEDGE**
> We know how knowledge passes from one mind to another, and Sheikh Bahmanpour traces the route. The speaker has an image in mind, and the body turns it into speech. The speech travels through the listener's nervous system and raises an image in the listener's mind. Of knowledge passing from one heart to another we have no such experience. He then recalls a report from Imam ʿAli (as): when the Prophet ﷺ was on his deathbed, a thousand doors of knowledge opened to Imam ʿAli's heart, and from each door a thousand more. In the Sheikh's telling, this knowledge did not come through language. It passed from heart to heart, and it is the kind of knowledge the ʿurafa' have.

The path is purification

> ***Point:*** *The path to knowing God is purification, which study serves but cannot replace.*
>
> 1. *If the light is everywhere and the heart is closed, the path is opening the heart: wayfaring (*suluk*), not thought (*fikr*).*
> 2. *Wayfaring has two parts: purify yourself, then wait for God to give the light.*
> 3. *The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah says who receives the light it asks for: whoever follows God's path (§88).*
> 4. *That path begins with the shariʿa, in doing what the Prophet ﷺ asked; without it there is no maʿrifah (Q 8:24).*
> 5. *Practice needs knowledge of what to practise, so study comes early, and then knowing and doing feed each other (Tabataba'i).*
> 6. *Therefore: without purification there is no maʿrifah, so study serves purification but cannot replace it.* (Story box: The philosopher and the ʿarif.)

If the light is everywhere and the heart is closed, the path to knowing God is the opening of the heart. Two Arabic words mark the difference between this path and study. Knowledge learned at a university or a seminary comes through thought (*fikr*): we think, put things together, analyse, and find out. Knowledge of God comes through wayfaring (*suluk*), the path to purity.

Wayfaring has two parts, and the Sheikh names both: "You purify yourself and then wait for Allah to put the light in your heart." The light is not absent while the heart waits, and the waiting is the patience of a heart that has done

its part and leaves the rest to God. The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah ties the light to the path in one line.

إِنَّ مَنِ ٱنْتَهَجَ بِكَ لَمُسْتَنِيرٌ

One who follows Your path is enlightened.[29]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

The same prayer asks, in the line this book opened with, for the eyes of the heart to be lit until they reach the source of God's grandeur. Here the prayer names who receives that light: the one who follows God's path.

Following that path begins with the shariʿa. Its first step is to polish the soul by doing whatever the Prophet ﷺ has asked. Without this there is no maʿrifah. The Qur'an calls the believers to answer Allah and the Apostle when he summons them to what will give them life (Q 8:24). That life comes when a person follows the Prophet completely.

Practice depends on knowing what to practise, and this is where study comes in. ʿAllama Tabataba'i, in the lectures recorded in *Kernel of the Kernels*, gives study an early place. Once the traveller has set out with a sincere intention, he says the first essential step is knowledge of shariʿa rules learned from a jurist. The traveller puts that knowledge into practice and persists until conviction and gnosis (*maʿrifah*) grow by degrees, "for knowledge gives birth to action and action in turn brings knowledge"[30].

Ayatullah Khomeini caveats the prominent position of learning with a warning, writing that "a learning that does not bring faith with it is the greatest of veils". Yet the veil cannot be avoided, only passed through: "one has to approach a veil in order to tear it into shreds". He adds that the sciences are "seeds of (spiritual) experience". He allows that high stations can be reached without them, but calls this unusual[31]. Without the polishing of the soul, in the Sheikh's words, there is no maʿrifah. Study can serve purification, but it cannot replace it.

[29] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §88.

[30] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 56.

[31] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 403.

STORY: THE PHILOSOPHER AND THE ʿARIF

Murtada Mutahhari records a meeting between Ibn Sina and Abu Saʿid ibn Abi al-Khayr, the latter being one of the most famous of all the ʿurafa'. Abu Saʿid was preaching on the necessity of deeds, and on obedience and disobedience to God. Ibn Sina answered him with a quatrain (a poem of four lines). Wherever God's favour and grace are found, it ran, "Let the not-done be like the done, the done like the not-done." The verse leaned on God's forgiveness in place of deeds. Abu Saʿid replied at once with a quatrain of his own, which ends: "Do not rely on forgiveness, for never / Was the not-done like the done, the done like the not-done"[32]. In Sheikh Bahmanpour's account, Ibn Sina later wrote to Abu Saʿid asking to learn from him. Mutahhari, who calls Ibn Sina "mainly a philosopher, not a mystic", notes that "especially towards the end of his life he developed mystic inclinations"[33].

Knowing by drawing near

Point: *Knowing God is a different kind of knowing, reached by purification, which study serves but cannot replace.*

1. *Therefore: what study cannot give comes through purification; the 'urafa' are brought near and know God by presence, as a light given to a purified heart, and that differs in kind from knowing about Him.*

Close: "Where, then, does an ordinary believer already stand on this path?" (Try this box.)

What study cannot give comes to the ʿurafa' through purification. Their nearness to God comes as the veils of the heart are unravelled: an action and a process that cannot be substituted by learning a definition. The knowing of the ʿurafa' is as present to their souls as hunger is to the one who fasts. It comes as a light that God gives to a purified heart, and so it differs in kind from knowing about God.

Where, then, does an ordinary believer already stand on this path?

➤ TRY THIS

In prostration in the daily prayer, many of us say, "Glory belongs to my Lord, the Exalted, and Him do I praise." ʿAllama Tabataba'i uses these words to show how

[32] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 29.

[33] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 42.

[34] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), pp. 56–57.

knowledge follows action[34]. For one week, in one prayer each day, say them slowly, “believing it to be a fact”. Notice your own lowliness with your forehead on the ground, then the majesty of the One you are calling exalted. From “a very minor action, such as this dhikr said in prostration”, he says, a person comes to discover God’s absolute majesty[35].

[35]‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), pp. 56–57.

3

You already know these words

وَّقَلْبِي بِحُبِّكَ مُتَيَّماً

And my heart enthralled by Your love![36]

Duʿa Kumayl

These words come near the end of Duʿa Kumayl, the prayer Imam ʿAli (as) taught to one of his closest companions Kumayl ibn Ziyad. Many of us hear it as the Mafatih recommends on Thursday evenings[37]. The line itself asks God for a heart enthralled by His love.

Such a heart, enthralled by the love of God, is one part of a quartet sought by ʿirfan. This chapter reveals how we already know these four desires of the seeker, with their requests familiar to our tongues: to be cut off from all else, to see God, to love God, and to be drawn near to God.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *duʿa*: supplication, any request made to God · *munajat*: an intimate, whispered prayer to God · *Mafatih al-Jinan*: the standard manual of Shia prayers[38] · *inqitaʿ*: severance of the heart from all but God

[36] *Duʿa Kumayl* (duas.org), §221.
[37] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 129.
[38] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 112.

Cut off from all else

Point: *The prayers' first request is a severance from everything but God, made in the heart.*

1. *Before the Munajat asks to see God, it asks to be cut off from everything else; seekers "have to cut off from everything first" (the Sheikh).*
2. *Taken at its word, that could mean leaving family, work and society; the Sheikh answers that the cutting off is "in the heart".*
3. *Duʿa Abu Hamza asks that love of the world leave the heart; Duʿa ʿArafah says God has already removed love for others from the hearts of those who love Him.*
4. *Both prayers remove a love from the heart. Therefore the severance the prayers ask for is in the heart.*

The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah asks to be cut off from everything before it asks to see God. This book opened on its request for light in the eyes of the heart. In the prayer, that line follows straight on from a request for severance. The order fits what Sheikh Bahmanpour says of those who seek God: they want to know Him and to look at Him, but "they have to cut off from everything first".

إِلٰهِي هَبْ لِي كَمَالَ ٱلاِنْقِطَاعِ إِلَيْكَ

My Lord, grant me complete severance of my relations with everything else[39]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

The Munajat asks for this severance (*inqitaʿ*) in full. Taken at its word, the request could sound like a call to leave family, work, and society behind. The Sheikh himself asks whether it is good to cut off from everything else completely. His answer is yes, "in the heart". Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali, recited on the nights of Ramadan, names what is to be cut away from the heart.

سَيِّدِي أَخْرِجْ حُبَّ ٱلدُّنْيَا مِنْ قَلْبِي

O my Master, (please) expel love for the world out of my heart[40]

Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali

[39] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §104.

[40] *Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali* (duas.org), §384.

Where Duʿa Abu Hamza asks that love of the world leave the heart, Duʿa ʿArafah, as given in the Mafatih, describes the same severance from God's side: He has already made it in the hearts of those He loves.

وَأَنْتَ ٱلَّذِي أَزَلْتَ ٱلأَغْيَارَ عَنْ قُلُوبِ أَحِبَّائِكَ حَتَّىٰ لَمْ يُحِبُّوا سِوَاكَ

It is You Who have removed love for others from the hearts of Your lovers so that they have loved none save You[41]

Duʿa ʿArafah

Both prayers speak of love, and both remove it from the heart. The severance the prayers ask for is therefore in the heart.

To see, to love, to draw near

> ***Point:*** *The prayers then ask for what ʿirfan seeks: to see God with the heart, to love Him, and to come near Him.*
>
> 1. *A heart cleared of everything but God is free for Him, and the prayers go on to ask Him for three things.* (Reader told: "three things: to see God with the heart, to love Him, and to come near Him".)
>
> a. *The first is sight, though the Qur'an says sight cannot perceive God (Q 6:103).*
> b. *The prayer asks for the eyes of the heart, the faculty behind our eyes that misses the signs (Ch 1); it is the light the last chapter described, which God gives to a purified heart, and Duʿa ʿArafah says He has lit it in His friends.* (Story box: the companion who saw paradise.)
> c. *The second is love: the Munajat asks for a place among God's friends, defined by love.*
> d. *That friendship is knowing God and loving Him, the two things ʿirfan seeks.*
> e. *The third is nearness, asked earlier in the same prayer.*
> f. *The Munajat asks for a heart whose passion brings it near; the Whispered Prayer of the Lovers asks to join those God has chosen for His nearness.*
> g. *Nearness is felt in prayer, as His presence when we call on Him.*
>
> 2. *Therefore, with nearness, the prayers have asked for all that ʿirfan seeks: sight, love and nearness.* (Last sentence of 1g's paragraph, as in Ch 1.)

A heart cleared of everything but God is free for Him. The prayers go on to ask for three things: to see God with the heart, to love Him, and to come near Him.

[41] Imam al-Husayn, *Duʿa ʿArafah* (duas.org), §783–784.

Note the explicit use of sight in the Munajat's request: "Enlighten the eyes of our hearts with the light of their looking at You"[42]. As we know, the Qur'an says that sight cannot perceive God (Q 6:103). Therefore, at first glance there is an apparent contradiction that people unfamiliar with the mystics' wording sometimes call a mistake.

The prayer does not ask for the eyes in our heads. It asks for the eyes of the heart. Our physical eyes work perfectly well, and yet still we miss God's signs, because the inner faculty behind them is blind. The prayer asks God to light that faculty. The light it asks for is the one the last chapter described, which God gives to a purified heart. Duʿa ʿArafah says He has already lit that light in the hearts of the friends of God (*awliya'*), whom it calls His intimate servants.

أَنْتَ ٱلَّذِي أَشْرَقْتَ ٱلْأَنْوَارَ فِي قُلُوبِ أَوْلِيَائِكَ

It is You Who have lit the illuminations in the hearts of Your intimate servants[43]

Duʿa ʿArafah

STORY: THE COMPANION WHO SAW PARADISE

The Prophet ﷺ once asked one of his companions how he was. The companion answered that he could see people's places in paradise, and the Prophet accepted what he said. Sheikh Bahmanpour tells this to show that the companion was not set apart from the others. He had purified his soul, and anyone who goes through that purification can see what others cannot. In a version in al-Kafi, quoted by Murtada Mutahhari, he is a young man named Harithah ibn Malik al-Ansari. In it the Prophet turns to his companions and says, "This is a man whose heart has been illuminated with the light of faith by God"[44]. It is the light Duʿa ʿArafah says God has lit in the hearts of His friends.

The Munajat makes the second request, for love, when it asks for a place among God's friends and defines that place by love.

[42]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165.
[43]Imam al-Husayn, *Du'a 'Arafah* (duas.org), §781.
[44]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 19.

إِلٰهِي أَقِمْنِي فِي أَهْلِ وِلايَتِكَ مُقَامَ مَنْ رَجَا ٱلزِّيَادَةَ مِنْ مَحَبَّتِكَ

My Lord, place me among Your friends in the position of one who hopes for an increase in Your love.[45]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

For the Sheikh, the friendship asked for here (*wilaya*) has two parts. One is maʿrifah: understanding God, looking at Him, and knowing Him. The other is love for Him. The love never stops, and the knowing keeps growing. These are the two things ʿirfan seeks, and both are in one line of the Munajat.

The third request, nearness, comes earlier in the same prayer.

إِلٰهِي هَبْ لِي قَلْباً يُدْنِيهِ مِنْكَ شَوْقُهُ

My Lord, provide me with a heart, the passion of which may bring it near You[46]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

Even that very desire, the longing itself that would carry us towards God, is something we ask Him for, and thus the line asks Him to provide to us a heart so inclined. The Whispered Prayer of the Lovers, one of fifteen whispered prayers printed with al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya, asks for a place among those God has chosen for His nearness.

[VERIFY: Arabic of Sahifa, Whispered Prayer of the Lovers]

My God, place us with him whom Thou hast chosen for Thy nearness and Thy friendship, ... granted gazing upon Thy face[47]

Whispered Prayer of the Lovers

The difference nearness makes is felt in prayer. For some of us, calling on God can feel like calling into the sky from far away. Others feel Him present when they call, and feel His response. With this third request, the prayers have asked

[45]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §92–93.

[46]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §82.

[47]Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 656.

for all that ʿirfan seeks: to see God with the heart, to love Him, and to be near Him.

A pupil reading above his level

> ***Point:*** *Words above our level are still ours to say, as an honour and as a plea from need.*
>
> 1. *Requests this high are the words of those brought near, yet ordinary believers are told to say them, like a primary school pupil handed university books.*
> 2. *The Sheikh's answer: we are honoured to be allowed to say them, though they are levels beyond us.*
> 3. *The prayers themselves speak from need rather than from rank, so rank is not a barrier to entry.*
>   a. *Duʿa ʿArafah comes to God with nothing to offer but its need of Him.*
>   b. *The Munajat goes further: even our turning towards God is His doing.*
> 4. *Therefore: a prayer that claims nothing for the one praying can be said by anyone, and God may grant a sincere request.*

The invitation to recite these words reaches us through the Mafatih al-Jinan, which most believers already own. Four of the prayers quoted in this chapter are in it, each set on a night or a day in the believer's year.

The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah is listed among the acts of the month of Shaʿban, and the Mafatih reports it as the prayer Imam ʿAli (as) and the other Imams used to say in that month[48]. It adds that it is "advisable to say it with presence of heart all the time"[49]. The full text, in Arabic and English, is given in the Appendix.

The other prayers have their own times. Duʿa Kumayl belongs to Thursday evenings and to the night of mid-Shaʿban[50]. Duʿa ʿArafah is the prayer of Imam al-Husayn (as) on the Day of ʿArafah[51]. Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali belongs to Ramadan, when Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin (as) said it in the last hour of each night[52]. Maliki Tabrizi tells the traveller not to forget it, and to say it every night or every other night, as his mood and situation allow[53].

[48] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 243.
[49] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 245.
[50] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 129.
[51] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 374.
[52] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 282.
[53] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 111.

Said on nights we keep, these words become familiar, and Ayatullah Khomeini could count on that familiarity. "You are already familiar with the words used in Imams' supplications," he told his listeners, before reading them lines from the Shaʿbaniyyah[54].

> ⧗ **HISTORY: THE MAFATIH AND THE SAHIFA**
>
> The prayers in this chapter reach ordinary believers through two books. The *Mafatih al-Jinan* ("Keys to the Heavens") gathers the supplications of the Imams, the words to be recited at particular times, and the forms for visiting the Imams' shrines. Its compiler, Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, was a scholar of vast learning who died in Najaf in 1359/1940[55]. Al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya, composed by Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin (as), is far older and is actually described by William Chittick as "the oldest prayer manual in Islamic sources". Shia tradition ranks it behind only the Qur'an and Nahj al-Balagha[56]. The fourth Imam died in Medina in 95/713–4, or a year earlier[57]. The fifteen whispered prayers, including the Whispered Prayer of the Lovers, were added to several modern editions of the Sahifa. They seem to have reached most Shia through ʿAllama Muhammad Baqir Majlisi, best known as the compiler of *Bihar al-Anwar*[58].

Reciting the words is not the same as comprehending what they describe. Maliki Tabrizi sees the supplications as a servant's own words rising to God. That, he writes, "is not accepted and comprehended by any one, except a small number of believers who are thoroughly familiar and enlightened"[59].

Sheikh Bahmanpour still recommends the Munajat to be recited in Shaʿban as often as possible. There is an important distinction between those who may begin reciting, and how far those reciters may reach. The Sheikh's recommendation is that the recitation is open to all, without a claim on how much is attainable to them from what they ask.

Words already on our lips

> ***Point:*** *The goal of ʿirfan is already on our lips: in these prayers, we have already begun to ask for it.*

[54] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 156.
[55] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 112.
[56] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 7.
[57] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 8.
[58] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 9.
[59] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 43.

1. *Access to these words is where an ordinary believer already stands on the path (answers the close of Ch 2).*
2. *The prayers ask for what ʻirfan seeks (§2), from need (§3), on nights we keep (§4).*
3. *Therefore the goal of ʻirfan is already on our lips: in these prayers, we have already begun to ask for it.*

Close: "These prayers keep asking God to work on the heart, the self within us. What is this self?"

Access and familiarity with these words is the starting point for an ordinary believer and already places them on the path. In the believer's own voice, on nights of Thursdays and those in Ramadan, they ask in their prayers for what ʻirfan seeks. The goal of ʻirfan is therefore not foreign to us: it is already on our lips. In saying these prayers, we have already begun to ask for it.

These prayers keep asking God to work on the heart, the self within us. What is this self?

➤ TRY THIS

This week, read the petitions of the Munajat Shaʻbaniyyah from §82 to §111 (in the Appendix) once, slowly, with the English beside the Arabic. The Mafatih advises saying the prayer "with presence of heart"[60]. As you read, notice the requests this chapter has followed: to be cut off from all else, to see, to love, and to draw near. When Shaʻban comes, follow the Sheikh's own advice and recite the whole prayer "as much as you can".

[60] Shaykh ʻAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 245.